

Rankine Cycle Analysis

EGR 218: Engineering Thermodynamics

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May 5, 2026

Abstract

Very Abstract, not very solid! Wow!

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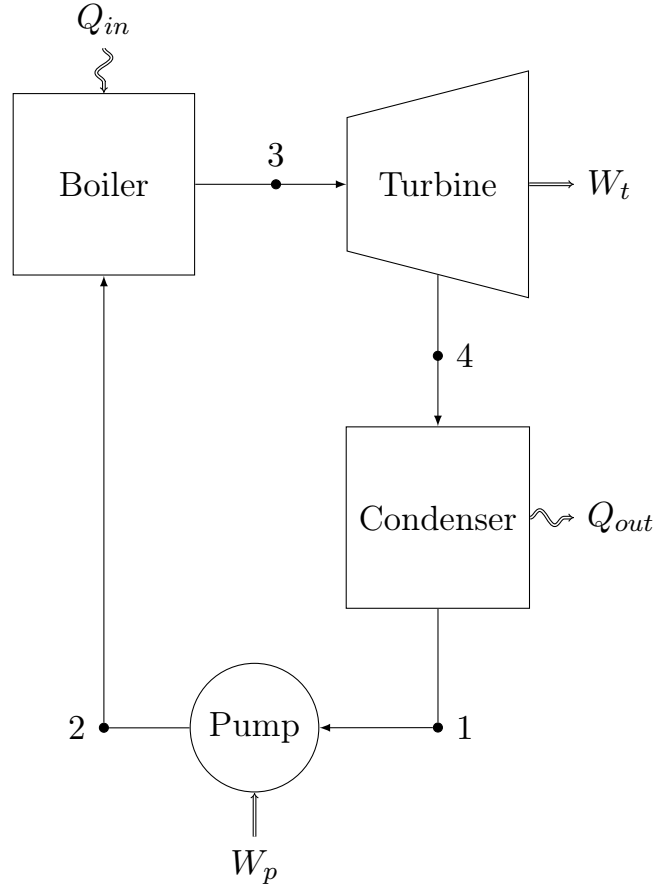


Figure 1: Schematic showing a Rankine cycle.

1 Introduction

1.1 Theoretical Background

The Rankine cycle consists of a boiler, a turbine, a condenser, and a pump, in a loop. An example of a Rankine cycle setup is shown in Figure 1. The Rankine cycle is characterized by its phase changes and work output [1].

The Rankine cycle consists of two state changes, one in the boiler, and one in the condenser. In the boiler the liquid is converted to a saturated vapor and the saturated vapor in the condenser is converted back into a saturated liquid. Heat is added in the boiler, the turbine outputs work, the condenser outputs heat, and work is done on the system by the pump. The pressure is constant from the output of the pump through the boiler to the input of the turbine. The turbine decreases the pressure, this decreased pressure is constant from the output of the turbine through the condenser to the input of the pump. The pump increases the pressure to restart the cycle. The liquid is heated in the boiler and then is cooled through the turbine. The temperature stays constant through the condenser. The temperature rises from the output of the pump to the boiler, due to increasing pressure and work done on the system by the pump. The cycle is isentropic through the pump and

through the turbine. These relationships are summarized in Table 1.

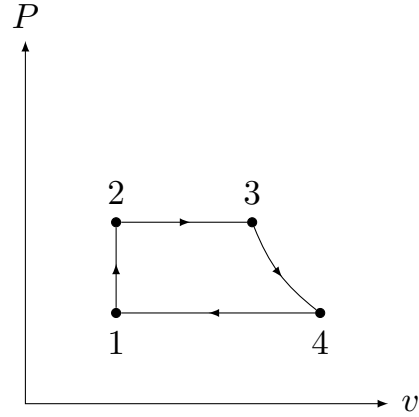
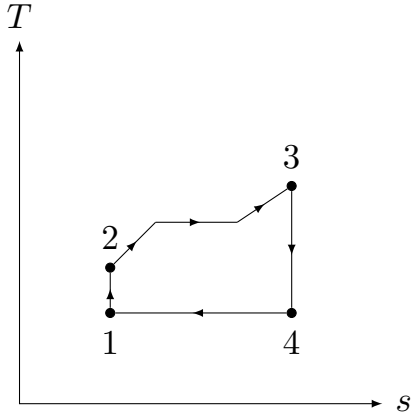


Figure 2: Ideal Rankine Cycle T-s Diagram

Figure 3: Ideal Rankine Cycle P-v Diagram

Points	Component	Variables
1-2	Pump	Isochoric, Isentropic.
2-3	Boiler	Isobaric.
3-4	Turbine	Isentropic.
4-1	Condenser	Isochoric, Isothermal.

Table 1: Summary of components and their locations.

1.2 Real World Examples

The Laguna Verde Nuclear Power Plant is a boiling water reactor in Veracruz, Mexico. The reactor was designed, unfortunately, by General Electric, not Westinghouse. The power plant provides for roughly 4.8% of Mexico's electricity production [2] and is the only nuclear power plant in the nation. There are reactors at the site. The reactors follow the Rankine cycle. Water is pumped into the reactor vessel where it is heated by the reactor itself, this is our boiler, the increased pressure steam then turns turbines before it is cooled back down, condensed, and reintroduced to the cycle. A NRC report [3] says the nuclear reactor's system "includes a direct cycle, forced circulation, boiling water reactor that produces steam for direct use in the steam turbine." This description highlights several components of our Rankine Cycle: forced circulation describes the work input done by the pump, boiling water reactor describes the boiler which increases pressure and temperature, and the turbine which produces the work output. Another key factor in this description is the reactor as being direct cycle. A direct cycle reactor passes water directly through the reactor, meaning the water is irradiated. The water being irradiated means that the cycle must be closed; this gives us our final component, the condenser which converts the steam back into water. The principal aspect of the Rankine cycle is a phase change, and secondarily work output. The reactor's cycle fills these two aspects, in the reactor boiling the water and the turbine extracting work.

2 Problem Setup

The given variables for our power plant analysis are the following:

Boiler pressure, $P_3 = 8$ MPa, condenser pressure, $P_1 = 10$ kPa, turbine inlet temperature, $T_3 = 480^\circ\text{C}$.

We can begin filling out the rest of the state variables by realizing that $P_2 = P_3$, $P_1 = P_4$, these are shown in Figures 2 and 3. As stated in the introduction, the cycle is isentropic through the pump, Point 1 to Point 2, and through the turbine, Point 3 and Point 4. This shows that $s_1 = s_2$ and $s_3 = s_4$. The boiler converts the saturated liquid into a saturated vapor, $x_3 = 1.0$, after the condenser the medium is a saturated liquid, $x_1 = 0.0$.

The rest of the state variables were calculated in EES, alternatively these values could be looked up in state tables. Table 2 displays the results.

Point	P, (kPa)	T, ($^\circ\text{C}$)	x	s, (kJ/($^\circ\text{K}\cdot\text{kg}$))	h, (kJ/kg)	v, (m^3/kg)
1	10.0	45.8	0.00	0.65	192	0.00101
2	8,000	46.1	-100 ¹	0.65	200	0.00101
3	8,000	480	1.00	6.67	3350	0.0404
4	10.0	45.8	0.80	6.67	2110	11.76

Table 2: Summary of state variables.

3 Energy Analysis

Variable	value
w_t	1240 kJ/kg
w_p	8.06 kJ/kg
q_{in}	3150 kJ/kg
q_{out}	1920 kJ/kg
w_{net}	1230 kJ/kg
η_{th}	39.1%

Table 3: Summary of energy analysis.

The equations, taken from a SFU lecture [4], used to analyze the power plant Rankine cycle are listed below, the actual calculation was done in EES:

To calculate the turbine work output, w_t :

$$w_t = h_3 - h_4$$

To calculate the pump work input, w_p :

$$w_p = h_2 - h_1$$

¹EES outputs a quality value of -100 for compressed liquids.

To calculate the heat input to the boiler, q_{in} :

$$q_{\text{in}} = h_3 - h_2$$

To calculate the heat rejected in the condenser, q_{out} :

$$q_{\text{out}} = h_4 - h_1$$

To calculate the net-work output from the cycle, w_{net} :

$$w_{\text{net}} = q_{\text{in}} - q_{\text{out}}$$

To calculate the efficiency of the cycle, η_{th} :

$$\eta_{\text{th}} = \frac{w_{\text{net}}}{q_{\text{in}}}$$

3.1 Diagrams

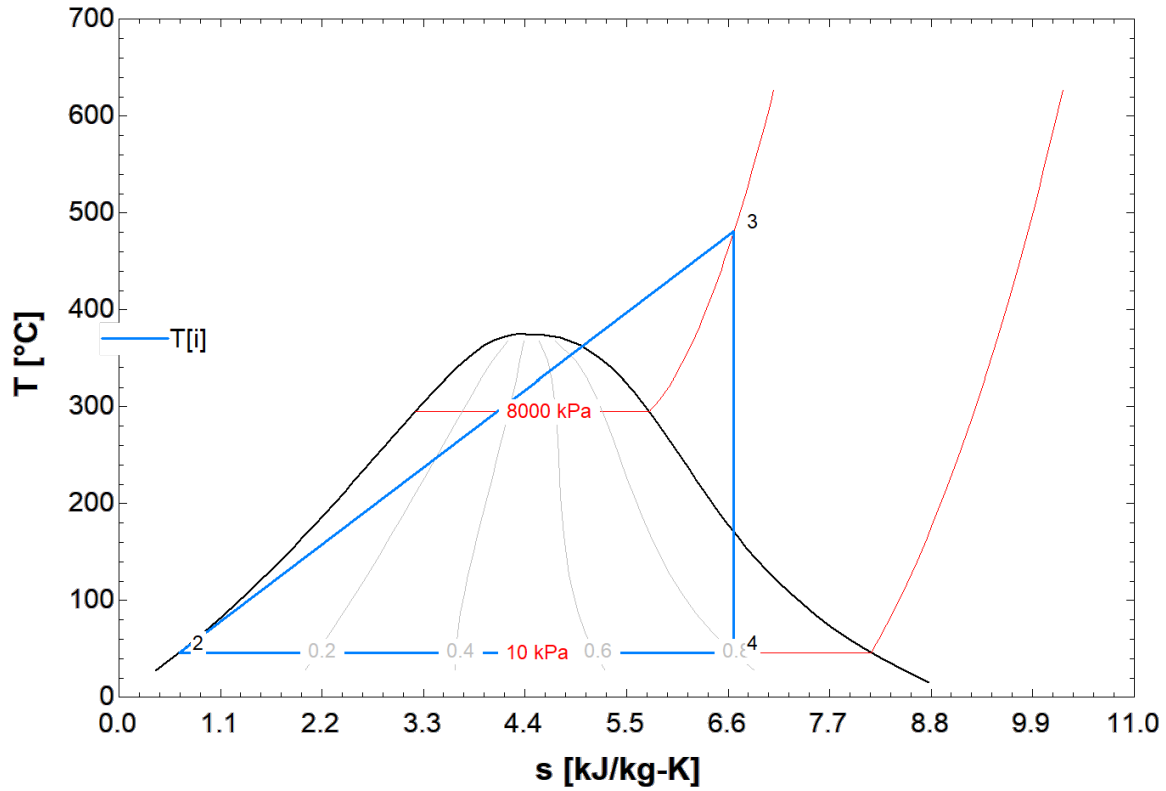


Figure 4: T-s diagram of the Rankine cycle using water. Point 1 is hidden by Point 2 as they are, relative to the scale, close together. The blue lines approximately show the cycle path. The red line at $P = 8000$ kPa is a more accurate representation of the path, as Figure 3 shows us that pressure is constant from Point 2 to Point 3, and Figure 2 demonstrates that the shape of the red line is what we should expect. The black line is the saturation bell.

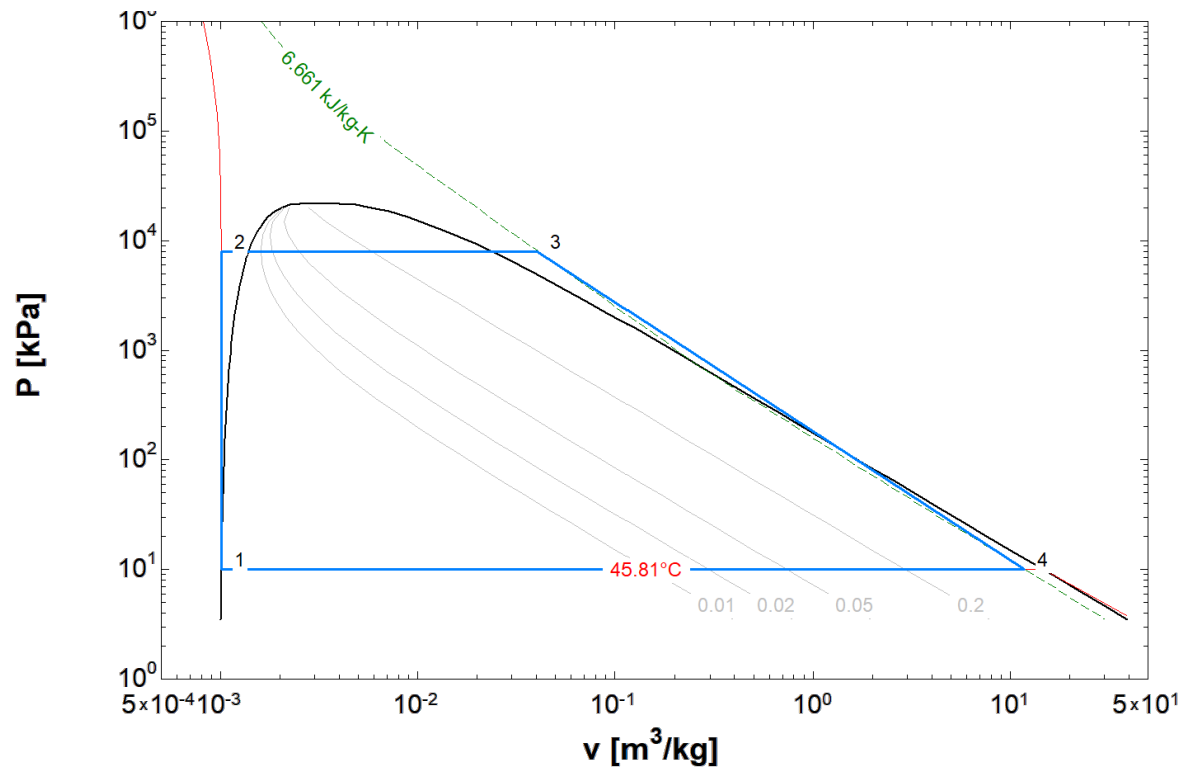


Figure 5: P-v diagram of the Rankine cycle using water. The blue lines approximately show the cycle path. The cycle from Point 3 to Point 4 is better shown by the entropy line, which is shown dotted in green, because entropy at these points is constant. The black line is the saturation bell.

Figure 5 demonstrates the principal factor of the Rankine cycle, the phase changes. In Figure 5 the cycle path starts at Point 1 with a quality of 0.0, a saturated liquid, it climbs outside, to the left of, the saturation bell at Point 2 where it becomes a compressed liquid, compressed by the pump. From Point 2 to Point 3 the path enters back under the saturation bell and comes outside above and to the right of saturation bell; the boiler converts the compressed liquid into a saturated vapor with quality 1.0. From Point 3 to Point 4 it enters back under the saturation bell, with a quality of 0.80.

4 Parametric Study

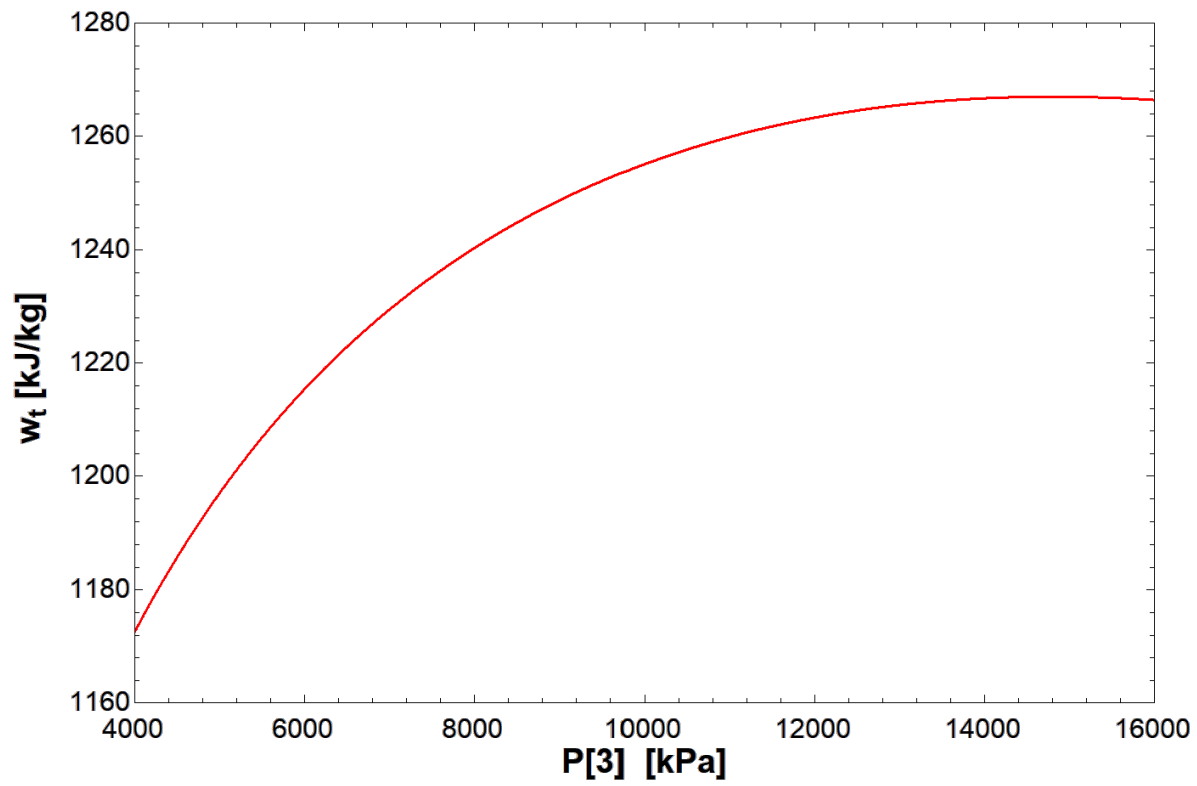


Figure 6: Parametric, work done by the turbine work output as affected by variable pressure exiting the boiler.

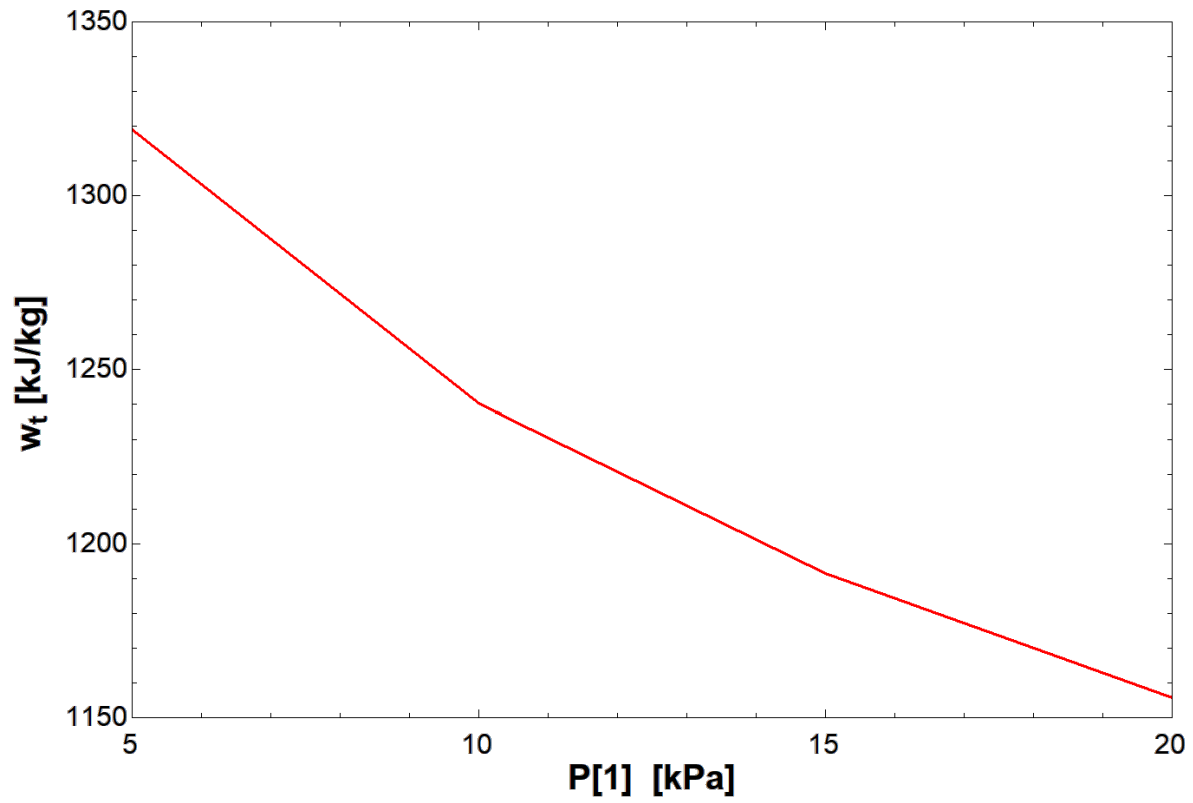


Figure 7: Parametric, Condenser Pressure x axis work done by turbine y axis. parametric graph, 4 intervals of pressure displayed on x axis

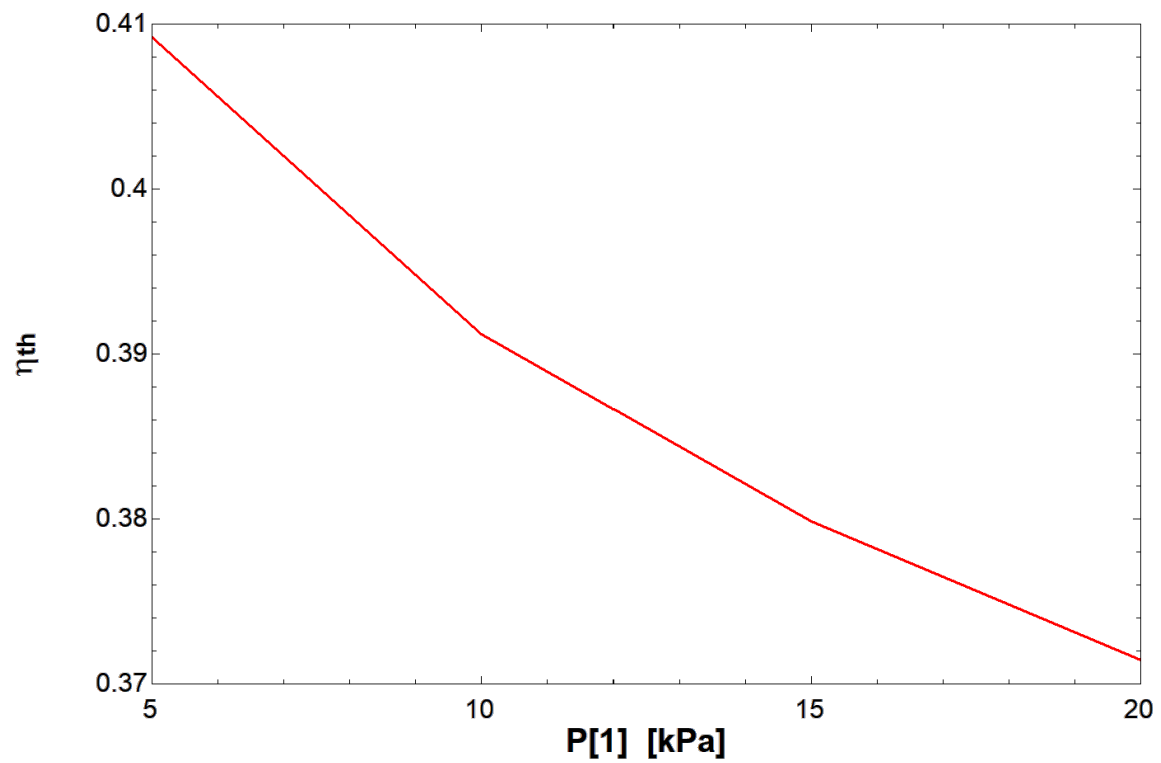


Figure 8: Parametric, efficiency (thermal) as affected by condenser pressure)

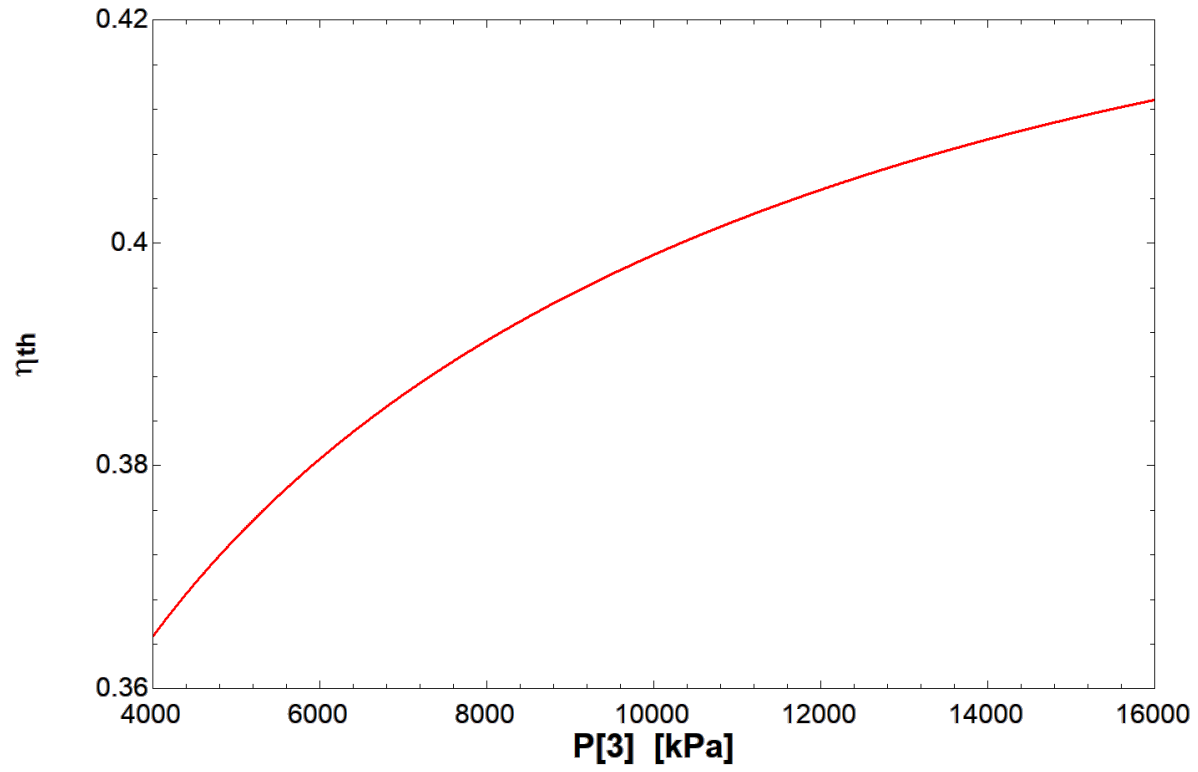


Figure 9: Parametric, Thermal efficiency as affected by boiler pressure

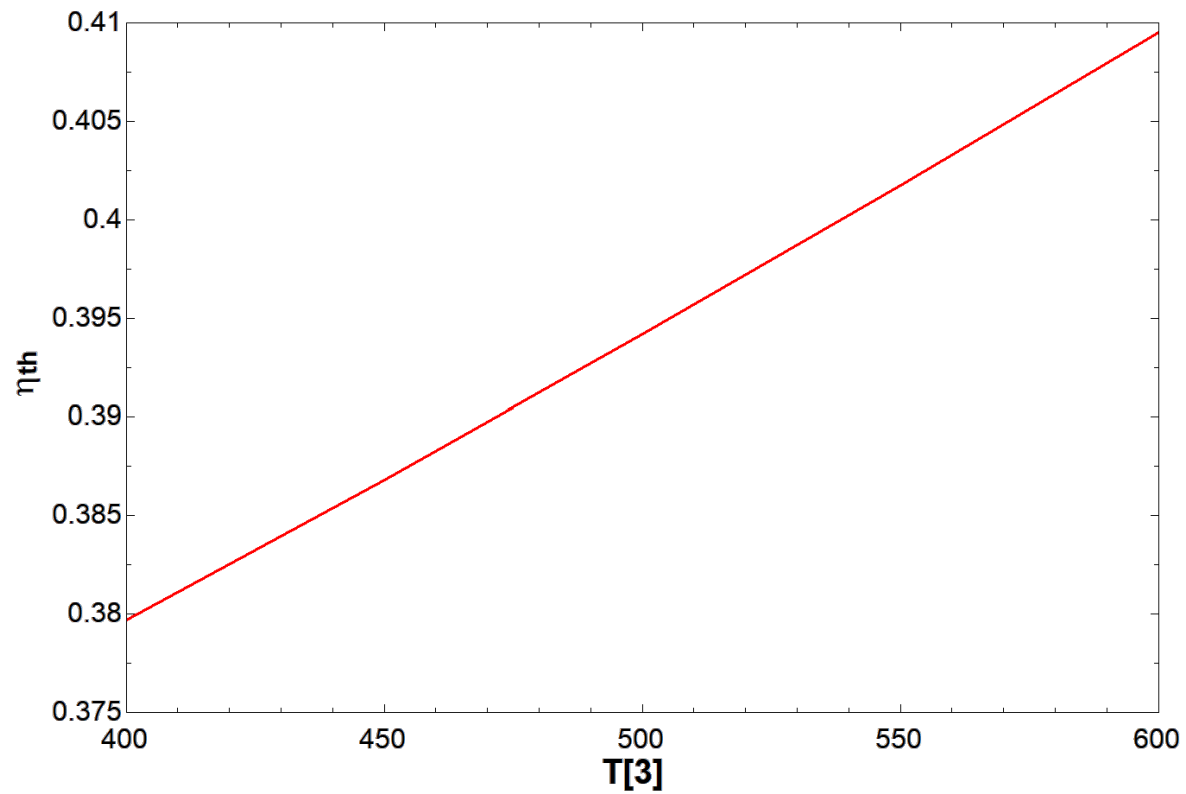


Figure 10: Parametric, thermal efficiency as affected by temperature at boiler exit

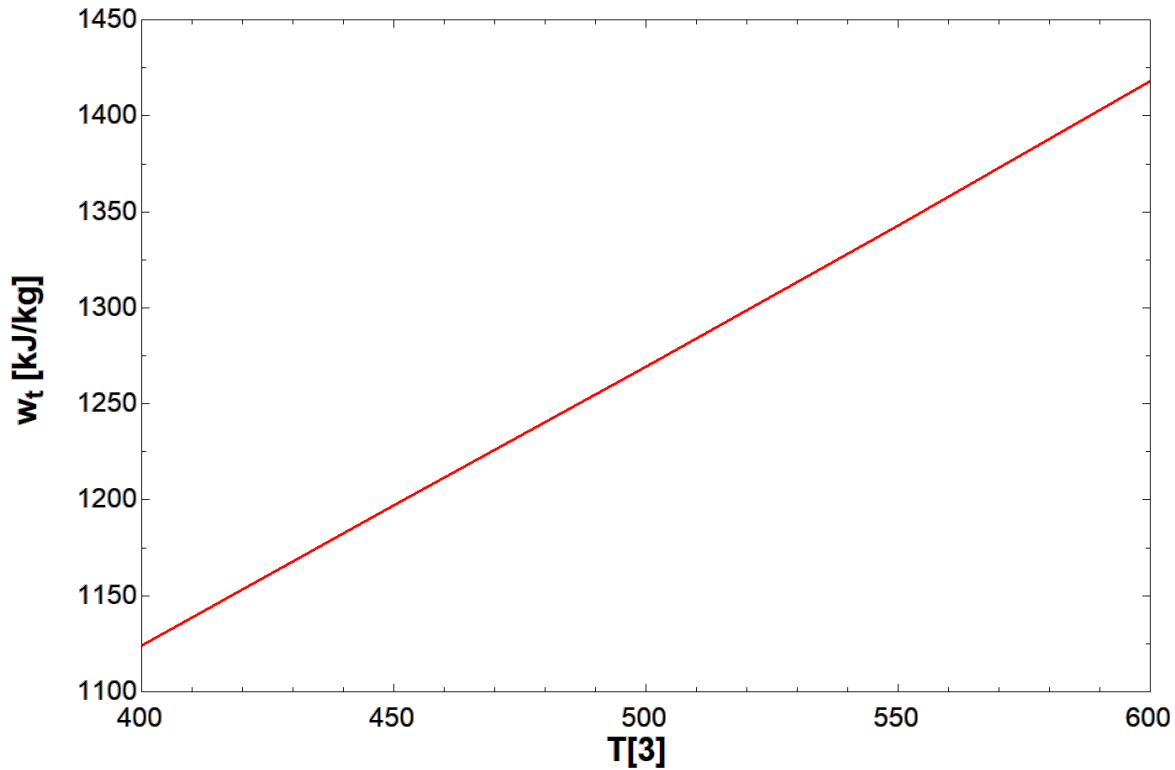


Figure 11: Parametric, work done by turbine (work out w/ units) as affected by boiler temperature (5 intervals of temp displayed on x-axis)

5 Discussion

6 Conclusion

References

- [1] I. A. Waitz, “Thermodynamics and Propulsion: The Rankine Cycle.” MIT OpenCourseWare (16.Unified), 2001. <https://web.mit.edu/16.unified/www/FALL/thermodynamics/notes/node65.html>. Accessed: 2026-05-05.
- [2] International Atomic Energy Agency, “PRIS – Country Details: Mexico.” Power Reactor Information System (PRIS) Database, 2026. <https://pris.iaea.org/pris/CountryStatistics/CountryDetails.aspx?current=MX>. Accessed: 2026-05-05.
- [3] U.S. Nuclear Regulatory Commission, “Laguna Verde, Units 1 and 2 - Individual Plant Examination of External Events (IPEEE) Submittal,” Technical Report ML012500140, U.S. Nuclear Regulatory Commission, 2001. <https://www.nrc.gov/docs/ML0125/ML012500140.pdf>.

- [4] M. Bahrami, “ENSC 461: Vapor Power Cycles.” Course Notes, Simon Fraser University, 2026. <https://www.sfu.ca/~mbahrami/ENSC%20461/Notes/Vapor%20Power%20Cycles.pdf>. Accessed: 2026-05-05.